

HE in FE: Vocationalism, Class and Social Justice

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Abstract

The paper draws on the Wolf (2015) report and other quantitative data, specifically that derived from HEFCE's Participation of Local Area (POLAR) classifications. In addition it explores key literature and debates that associate HE in FE (Higher Education in Further Education) with the pursuit of social justice. This enables an interrogation of conceptualisations of vocationalism as well as a consideration of its articulation with class and gender. Whilst the paper is set within a particular and English socio-economic context, it addresses issues that have a much broader global significance. The paper argues that whilst HE in FE has limited traction in facilitating social mobility it does serve as a resource in the struggle for social justice.

Key Words: HE in FE, vocationalism, class, gender, social justice, ideology, widening participation, social mobility

Introduction

This paper seeks to contribute to debates surrounding HE in FE by engaging with the key literature whilst also developing an analysis of the available statistics. For the most part where statistics are drawn upon in current writing these are used in a descriptive manner to set the context for wider debate (Bathmaker 2015; Robinson 2012; but see Rashid and Brooks undated). So for example, Bathmaker (2015) seeks to explore and develop a Bourdieusian framework to examine HE in FE. Whereas Robinson (2012) draws upon empirical data derived from students to examine perceptions of foundation degrees, locating this within an analysis founded upon critical hermeneutics. By this she has in mind Kincheloe and McLaren's (2002 98) notion of critical hermeneutics which is used as a form of cultural criticism or ideological critique to reveal the power dynamics surrounding social and cultural contexts and practices (Robinson 2012, 457). These analyses sit alongside research on HE in FE that seeks to place analysis within a social justice framework. This may derive from a consideration of the manner in which HE in FE secures the interests of the powerful or alternatively through attempts to undermine and transcend the 'hidden injuries' of class (Cobb and Sennett 1993; Coffield, Costa, Müller and Webber, 2014).

Alongside an engagement with the key literature, the paper seeks to examine what a statistical analysis can tell us about processes associated with social background in relation to HE in FE by drawing on available official data. Our analysis also entails a consideration of notions of vocationalism and its relationship to para-professionalism. Although our discussion is set within the English context, it addresses issues that have a much broader global significance. The re-engineering of HE is a case in point and its relationship to the reproduction or interruption of patterns of inequality in wider society. Politicians all over the world are infatuated with education policy because it is thought to provide a plausible instrument for social and economic development (Wolf 2004, 321; 2015, 72-73), both of which are apparent in justifications for opening up access to higher education for under-represented groups. The expansion of HE, in England often referred to in policy as Widening Participation (WP), has been seen by many states and supranational bodies as

pivotal to the development of knowledge based economies (Cable 2014; D'Costa 2015; Sachini 2014). Sweden, Australia and Germany, amongst other nations, set targets for increased participation in HE and the Organisation of Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD) has also explicitly supported this expansion (Gale 2012, 240; Wolf 2010, 316). With now obvious hubris Garret Fitzgerald, who was the prime minister of Ireland throughout much of the 1980s, claimed the success of Ireland's then Celtic Tiger economy was due in part to "the long established and ... universal conviction that education is key to economic growth" (Fitzgerald 2004, quoted in Wolf 2004, 316). The devastating impact of the subsequent economic crisis has dampened rhetoric associated with the knowledge economy, but there has remained in England as elsewhere a policy discourse that perceives enhancing the skills of the nation's workforce as a means to achieve national economic development. It is in this context that universities and HE are to play a pivotal role. Wolf, however, doubts the sustainability or economic justification of this stance and suggests that the development of vocational education in Further Education would make a greater contribution to skill development, warning against the colonisation of vocational education by universities (Wolf, 2015, 76; and see Porter and Simons 2015).

Whilst the claims made for the development of a knowledge-based economy are overstated, the concept does point towards changes in the economic structure as well as the demand for particular types of labour. The irony is that in the economies of the global north, under and unemployment, together with over-qualification are features of the labour market and specifically those facing graduates (Allen and Ainley 2014; Marsh 2011). Furthermore, this co-exists with the continued significance of 'rotten' jobs (Keep and James 2010, 2012) whereby people 'churn' between low paid and low skilled work which exists alongside periods of unemployment (Shildrick, MacDonald, Webster, and Garthwaite 2012). Blacker (2013) is not alone in suggesting that swathes of the working class have effectively been expunged, or in his terms, eliminated from the labour market (and see Gorz, 2010). In the emerging economies of the world Davis (2006) has noted a not dissimilar process and the increasing significance of surplus labour that is more extensive than that captured by the Marxist notion of the industrial reserve army of labour (Marx 1976 [1867], 781-794). This is because Davis' surplus population has been permanently excluded from the formal waged economy, rather than being drawn in from time-to-time as would be the case with the traditional reserve army of labour. All of these processes are placed under the hegemony of neo-liberalism in which the development of human capital is rhetorically constructed as pivotal to the development of individual and societal competitiveness. Somewhat contradictorily labour markets in both the global north and south are increasingly characterised by precariousness that echo Shildrick et al's (2012) notion of 'churning'. Brown, Lauder and Ashton (2011) note that even amongst those deemed to be knowledge workers there is a polarity between individuals thought to possess 'rare' and 'remarkable' skills who are globally mobile and part of an elite sector of the labour force - Dorling's (2014, 2015) 1 percent. This elite is set against those knowledge workers who encounter the standardisation of their labour processes, deskilling and concomitantly reducing incomes.

So how does all this sit with an analysis of HE in FE? Firstly, it is important to note that English colleges of Further Education (FE) bear some resemblance to Community colleges in the US and Technical and Further Education colleges (TAFE)

in Australia. Further Education colleges in England have been concerned with vocational and technical education but they do much more than this, having an important role in 16-19 education, adult education and latterly provision for 14-19 year olds. FE colleges are diverse institutions whose provision can range from basic skills to degree level work, as seen in HE in FE. Colleges are marked by their particular histories as well as and relatedly the local and regional contexts in which they are placed (see Lucas 2004). HE in FE can be delivered by various providers that could include private training agencies, professional associations as well as large employers, as would be the case with higher level apprenticeships in fields such as aerospace and engineering.

It is also necessary to consider the neo-liberal context in which educational institutions operate, as well as their 'relative autonomy' which is set within quasi-market relations. In current conditions educational institutions are to act as if they are businesses and are to continually search for new markets and win customers from competitors. Inevitably this leads to waste, duplication and over-supply of provision. In addition the perversities embedded in state funding regimes will partly shape institutional practices which aim to maximise income and secure the immediate future of the institution. For example, Wolf (2011) has noted the proliferation of valueless vocational qualifications which are nominally at level 2 (equivalent to International Standard Classification of Education, (2012) level 2) (and see Wolf 2015, 39, 60). The way in which provision develops will be influenced by a number of factors amongst which will be the local labour market, the market for courses as well as the available funding streams, the most important deriving from the state. But these may also be mediated by the way the college constructs its mission in relation to widening participation, social justice, and of course the needs of the community it serves. This is a community that may include not only its users, students, employers and so on, but also the college's conceptualisation of its civic responsibility to the wider populace. Amongst at least some staff in colleges of further education the latter concerns may rank highly (Daley, Orr and Petrie 2015).

In some respects teachers' interest in increasing the participation of excluded and disadvantaged groups reflects an interest in social justice and a concern to provide enhanced opportunities for non-traditional learners. The result is that such teachers may find themselves becoming interested in HE in FE. At the same time teachers committed to professional development may wish to teach on and develop Foundation Degrees (Fd) which like Higher National Diplomas and Certificates (HND/C) before them were to offer vocationally orientated sub-degree qualifications. The complexity of FE can be further evidenced in its role in providing professionally orientated qualifications for those involved in accountancy, personnel management and so on. In the following our focus is on non-traditional students, HE in FE and social justice. However there are two additional points to be made. The first concerns binaries whereby FE is contrasted with HE. Such a binary plays down institutional differentiation both within and between FE and HE. Not only are there dual sector institutions (Bathmaker, 2009; Parry, Callender, Scott, and Temple 2012) but 'FE in HE' will also be present in HEIs as found in elements of professional development. This is notwithstanding the way in which many writers seek to contrast HE in FE with HE in HE. Lea and Simmons (2012), Gale, Turner and McKenzie (2011) Griffiths and Lloyd (2009) amongst others point towards the distinctiveness of HE in FE. Such writers draw our attention to the supportive pedagogic relations that are deemed to be a feature of the sector, its small classes as well as the

commitment of FE teachers to HE provision. Alongside this analysis writers make a comparison between the working conditions of HE in FE teachers and their university counterparts. A number of themes are raised; the limited space for scholarship and research in the FE setting, the differing conditions faced by FE teachers in contrast with those in HE and the cultural features of HE which prioritise publication and research (Schofield and Burton 2015; Feather 2014). These themes can be drawn upon by those working in FE to call for equivalent conditions to those of their university colleagues. Such comparisons are in part ideological in that they play down the differentiations within the university sector as well as divisions that exist between a research elite and other academics. However, these comparisons can be mobilised, becoming an element in a professionalising project (Abbott 1988) that seeks to mark up the distinctiveness of HE in FE teachers. We are reminded of Tipton's (1973) classic study of a technical college whose teachers sought to gain degree level work thereby increasing job satisfaction and academic status. Such a strategy is not only one of professionalisation but also of class, being an attempt to gain positional advantage to enhance the status accorded to practitioners. Such a class project allied to that of professionalisation is reflected in a struggle that calls for an acknowledgement of the demands of teaching in the sector, the necessity for FE teacher education and the need to value vocational education and training (Smith and O'Leary 2015). This is set within a social justice agenda and against the perversities of neo-liberalism and state policy that discounts the need for teacher education in this sector. This project calls for parity between mainstream FE teachers and school teachers but also between HE in FE teachers and those in universities. This is not only a class project but is also gendered as Simmons and Thompson (2007) note by drawing our attention to the feminisation of teacher education in the FE sector.

Issues to do with feminisation, class and para-professionalisation can also be seen in research that addresses Early Years Fds (Moss 2010; Morgan 2015; Osgood 2010; Sims-Schouten and Stittrich-Lyons 2014). Here the interest in social justice can be seen in a project that seeks to enhance the status of those, mainly women, who work with pre-school children. The aim is to call for a recognition of the demands involved in working with young children and the necessity for a professional education that extends beyond training. These programmes seek to deliver a professional education that along with other HE in FE, Fds and degrees which have a vocational focus aim to align employability, work readiness and workplace skills with the academic underpinning of practice (Rutt, Gray, Turner, Swain, Hulme and Pomeroy 2013). Such a stance can co-exist with an expansive understanding of vocational education and training, one that is not only concerned with the development of workplace skills, knowledge and dispositions but which also conceives of occupations having a broader civic and democratic remit (Winch 2012).

It is important to place HE in FE within a relational understanding of educational institutions. Such an understanding leads us to consider the manner in which particular institutions relate to patterns of inequality present in wider society. This is important as it points towards structural relations and offers a corrective to those accounts that pathologise particular institutions or learners. Such a stance means that we consider the way in which privilege is reproduced in relation to class, race and gender. In the following we interrogate the available quantitative data to determine what it tells us about these processes. However, there is one final caveat. It is very important to set structural relations within a broader neo-liberal and

capitalist framework - if not, analyses can end up emphasising divisions amongst those who sell their labour, the better-off compared with the less well-off, or accounts that stress generational inequalities thereby neglecting the elite, Dorling's 1 percent (McKnight 2015; Willetts 2010).

Whilst the paper is set within a particular and English socio-economic context where policymakers have typically linked widening participation in HE to improving opportunities for social mobility (see for example Cabinet Office 2011, 48), it addresses issues that have a much broader global significance and in particular what is understood by social justice and social mobility and how these relate to widening participation in HE. In America, for example, policies linked to broadening access to HE through Community Colleges have been associated with meritocratic ideals of individual talent being the determinant of social distinction (Liu, 2011).

The British government has been especially keen to promote and even quantify social mobility, if not social justice, which it defines as "a measure of how free people are to improve their position in society" (Cabinet Office, 2011 15). In the same document the government specifies its commitment to a relative measure of social mobility and to the upward movement of people by comparison to general society. That narrow understanding of social mobility suggests a restricted conception of tackling inequality, which entails society's divisions remaining in place while a few enterprising and deserving individuals may climb over them. Lingard, Sellar and Savage (2014) refer to this as an equity model. It reduces social mobility to a technical issue that ignores the broader philosophical questions concerned with social justice and its relationship to the patterning of inequality in relation to race class and gender. These are questions which the notion of equality addresses. Narrow and technicised models of social mobility fail to offer a strategy for improving the lot of the many. Moreover, as Crawford et al. (2011, 6) point out, any relative measure of social mobility "necessarily implies downward mobility for children from rich/middle income families", which poses significant political challenges for any government to express. So, at least in England, downward mobility is rarely mentioned. Government agencies in England have, however, been explicit about recognising the hierarchy of educational institutions (see Office for Fair Access n.d.) and Hayward and Hoelscher (2011, 317) note that whatever "redistributive potential" WP has may be dependent on the type and status of HE institutions where students enrol. This is also suggested by the Sutton Trust's (2010, 2) study that found the proportion of children on free school meals (the UK government's measure of deprivation which accounts for a little under 20 per cent of children) that went on to enrol at the 25 most selective universities in England between 2005-06 and 2007-08 was just 2 per cent. That proportion compared with 72.2 per cent for other state educated students and 25.8 per cent for privately educated students, who constitute only 7 per cent of all children. The type of institution matters for our analysis, which examines the opposite end of the HE hierarchy from the most selective universities to assess the effect of participation in HE in FE on social mobility. Based on data available from official sources it questions reductive assumptions about WP and its connection to upward social mobility, let alone social justice. That data is, however, limited. This analysis is based on data for HE courses in England that are funded through the Higher Education Funding Council for England (HEFCE). These courses are the majority of that provision but they do not include courses funded in other ways, for which there is no

adequate national data. Similarly, the government only systematically collects data for young people (starting their courses before the age of 21) who are on full-time courses. Given that FE colleges are likely to have more part-time and mature students this immediately suggests that inferences from the data need be cautious (Parry et al. 2009, 12-13). Nonetheless some trends can be discerned. We begin by examining some of the recent changes in English HE provision.

Trends in England's higher education sector

Perhaps the most striking recent change in the pattern of HE enrolments in England has been the steep decline in part-time students. Between 2008 and 2012 the number of entrants to part-time HE courses in England (based on the official definition of studying for less than 21 hours per week or less than 24 weeks per year) fell by 37 per cent (Oxford Economics 2014, ii). The number of part-time undergraduate students in 2013-14 was half what it was in 2010-2011 (HEFCE, 2014, 4). As well as the recession leading to individuals and organisations having less money to pay for part-time professional development courses, Oxford Economics (2014, 31) in their report for HEFCE identify certain government policies as contributing to this decline. These include the removal of funding in 2008 from those students studying towards a qualification that was of a lower or equivalent level to one they already held. There has also been reduced funding for postgraduate students, many of whom were part-time, as well as other financial disincentives for HEIs to offer part-time course. Fees for part-timers rose by 27 per cent between 2007-08 and 2010-2011 (Callender et al. 2012, 10), well above inflation. College-based HE may be cheaper than university-based but has still risen significantly in price, and the number of part-time HE students in colleges has also reduced, though not by the extent of other HEIs. In reducing opportunities for adults to study while they work this unintended collapse of part-time provision may well have had a more profound and damaging impact on opportunities for social mobility than any intentional policy had to enhance it. In addition Wolf notes that between 2011–13 and 2013-14 there was a large increase in enrolment for HNDs, a full time vocationally orientated sub-degree level 4 qualification, mostly offered in FE colleges and which is similar to Fds. She further suggests that,

As caps on individual institutions have been removed, and as the declining size of the home cohort left three-year degree places unfilled, there has been less reason for institutions to offer, or students to enrol for, [two year] foundation degrees [or HNDs] rather than three-year Bachelors programmes. (2015, 60)

Parry (2009, 336) also identified the concentration of other undergraduate courses within FE, which has become even more rapid. “How did this happen?” asks Randall and the reply to his own question is pertinent:

Put simply, universities will do what they are paid to do. But if they are paid without being told what to do, they will do what they like. And they like teaching for degrees.

(Randall 2011, 62)

Universities are most likely to sign students up for a full degree course to help ensure three or more years' income and have other qualifications such as a foundation degree only as an expedient lower exit award. So, other undergraduate courses are still closing in HEIs but they have stabilized in colleges (HEFCE 2014a, 15-16).

These structural changes associated with the current tuition fees regime alongside the impact of the economic crisis have had a significant effect on HE in FE, though any national generalisations about HE in FE have to be made with caution. There are enormous regional differences in what HE in FE provision is available, which can be dominated in certain areas by single colleges. In 2010-11, for example, of the 17,445 first degree entrants in all English FE colleges, over 3,000 went to just three FE institutions while the majority of colleges had fewer than one hundred such students. This divergence demonstrates how a college with the intention to be a major HE provider can have a powerful local effect, especially where there are no local universities. Nor can it be generally asserted that only students with low entry grades take HE in FE courses; 3,000 students with the equivalent of the highest A level (the major academic qualifications taken at the age of 18) grades of A,B,B or better were in college-based HE courses in 2012-13 (HEFCE 2014a, 4). With these caveats about generalization, our study nonetheless seeks to describe the overall provision and proportions of HE in FE in England to highlight any systemic effects of this provision on widening participation and then on social mobility.

As noted above, official datasets are particularly inadequate for HE in FE and data are only systematically and consistently available for full-time students who started HE before the age of 21. As HE in FE students are older and more likely to be part-time than university students this limitation in the dataset is especially important for HE in FE. Consequently, the following comparisons based on full-time, young students are restricted though they may still be instructive. For fifteen years HEFCE has been using Participation of Local Area (POLAR) classifications to denote the level of participation of young people in HE within small geographical areas that divide the whole of England. These areas are grouped by quintiles ranked from 1 (lowest rate and considered most disadvantaged) to 5 (highest rate and considered most advantaged). Harrison and McCaig (2014) argue that this data represents an ecological fallacy; that 'you are where you live'. In other words, any statistical inference made about individual students based on their neighbourhood is problematic (see also Osborne & Shuttleworth 2004 for a similar conclusion). Harrison and McCaig's statistical analysis of what HEFCE refers to as "low participation neighbourhoods" (LPNs) based on POLAR classifications has found that LPNs have limited granularity; that more disadvantaged families live outside these neighbourhoods than live within them; and that LPNs have a higher than expected proportion of relatively advantaged families (ibid.; 1). While highly critical of the diverse uses of LPN statistics in policy, Harrison and McCaig nevertheless conclude that they:

serve a useful purpose as a simple and reliable (in the statistical sense) proxy for a broad concept of historical educational disadvantage. They are useful in identifying the sorts of areas in which young people with the potential to enter higher education with additional support might be found.

(ibid., 21)

Based on this “simple and reliable” proxy in the absence of others, HE in FE students are more likely than university students to come from areas that have had low levels of participation in HE (HEFCE 2013a, 8). Furthermore, HEFCE (2013b, 17) data between 1998-99 and 2011-12 show the trend in young participation in HE across all five POLAR quintiles has been steadily increasing. More young people from every echelon of society are attending HE which means there has been widening access of the most disadvantaged to HE. WP policies have been successful. There is, however, a steady differential of 40 per cent in the level of participation between the lowest and highest quintile. That is, while the overall proportion of young people accessing HE has increased, in 2011-12 60 per cent of young people in quintile 5 (the most privileged) were accessing HE while the figure for those in quintile 1 (the least privileged) was 20 per cent, a forty point differential. In 2004-5, the differential was identical and in 98-99 it was 38. We may surmise that the lower participation quintiles are being increased partly by growth in HE in FE while all HE, including elite HE, is growing at a similar rate. POLAR data that shows HE students from the lowest quintile are twice as likely to be taught at a further education college as a university supports that surmise, which may also explain the stability of the proportion of HE in FE while total HE numbers have grown. The inverse is the case for the highest quintile. See Table 1 below.

INSERT TABLE 1

Other sources of data suggest a similar pattern of steady growth in access to HE across society. As Table 2 below shows, even as the overall proportion of young students in HE across the UK increased from 30 to 35 per cent, the gap between those students who had at school received free school meals and those who did not only moved one percentage point. Certainly, more disadvantaged young people have had access to HE, participation in HE has widened, but the differential in the rate of participation with more advantaged student remains. The cross-section of the population in HE is similar in its proportions, even if the numbers in that cross-section are stable.

TABLE 2

Given this data, we may infer that the type of students in FE has remained consistent even as the provision in FE has changed. So, as FE colleges transform their HE provision and as HE provision has generally grown, the students proportionally remain those who are most disadvantaged. This data does indicate wider access to HE, albeit not necessarily on full degree courses, but they do not indicate social mobility let alone social justice, as the differences in participation associated with social background remain intact. This also may help to explain the stability of HE in FE as a proportion of HE provision. The ceiling is rising as quickly as the floor so simply accessing HE is no longer a meaningful marker of social distinction. Arguably, the stability of the proportion of students in HE in FE provision exists because of the

stubborn inequality of English society, even as the form of that inequality has altered.

HE in FE and social mobility

Given the claims made of HE in and the stability of this proportion how effective is HE in FE in relation to upward social mobility in England? HEFCE (2013c, 3) state, “Leavers obtaining HE qualifications from study registered at [FE colleges] had notably different destinations profiles to equivalent qualifiers from HEIs.” The proportion of graduates from FE colleges in 2010-11 employed full-time in professional occupations was 8 per cent, compared with that of graduates from HEIs, which was 23 per cent (HEFCE 2013c, 20). Between 2008-2009 and 2010-11 between 4 and 6 percent more FE graduates were unemployed than graduates from universities and the latter are also more than twice as likely to be in further study. In 2010-11 6 per cent of HE in FE graduates went on to further study against 16 per cent of university graduates (ibid. 2013, 11). Postgraduate study, which is more available in HEIs, is arguably becoming a new and necessary distinguisher of social position for advantaged groups in English society.

For salaries there are similar discrepancies. As the table below indicates, mean starting salaries for HE in FE graduates were 16 per cent lower than those from HEIs in 2010-11, which matched the pattern of the previous five years (HEFCE 2013c, annex C11). The median salary differences are even greater because more HE in FE graduates earn less than HEI graduates. Whatever its use value, the exchange value of HE in FE is consistently less than that for other HE courses (and see Youth Cohort Study & Longitudinal Study of Young People in England 2010, 2011).

TABLE 3

While HE in FE has widened participation, it has not systematically enabled relative upward social mobility at least as measured by income. This finding echoes Brown *et al.* (2008, 17) who found that the expansion of access to higher education more generally in the UK “has failed to narrow income inequalities even amongst university graduates”. The assertion from the think-tank Policy Exchange (Hartley and Groves 2011, 6) that colleges “can play a major role in widening participation and improving social mobility” conflates the concepts of WP and social mobility and elides the difference. There is a fundamental discrepancy between the government's stated intentions for HE in FE, at least in regard to social mobility, and what HE in FE can achieve, no matter how efficient the sector is. As Marsh (2011) reminds us, if we wish to seriously address questions of social justice and poverty we need to reduce the income of the top 1% of wage earners and enhance those of the poor. This is a political issue that cannot be addressed by education. In less austere times Bernstein (1970) pointed out that ‘education cannot compensate for society’, but this is not to claim that education cannot be a resource in the struggle for social justice (Apple 2013).

In the preceding we have drawn on material derived from HEFCE POLAR data, which can be used to comment on the significance of social background in educational advantage and disadvantage. Social background can be used as a gloss for class. However, this material needs to be set alongside other data that points towards the intersection of race, class and gender in educational processes. This is perhaps most noticeable in relation to those courses that address the vocational interests of students (see for example, Youth Cohort Study & Longitudinal Study of Young People 2009, 2010; House of Commons Education Committee 2014; WISE, 2013; and discussion in Avis 2016). This material points towards a number of familiar features, the relationship between class and educational outcomes, gender and subject studied, the higher prevalence of ethnic minorities in FE and so on.

Human Capital, Social Justice and Curriculum

Though a desire for social mobility may partly explain the commitments of many governments to increasing the numbers of students in HE, ideas loosely associated with human capital are a more dominant motivation. The OECD (2001, 18) defines human capital as: *The knowledge, skills, competencies and attributes embodied in individuals that facilitate the creation of personal, social and economic well-being*. The concept of human capital renders individuals responsible for their own perpetual development to enhance their value in the market place, regardless of structural restrictions. Hence, for example, there is the promotion of employability skills amongst young people, ignoring the collapse of job opportunities for those young people following the economic crisis. Zipin et al. give this short shrift:

‘If you work hard enough you can attain your dream’. This is the hope-goading gloss on the other side of sterner neoliberal injunctions, carried in policy and political discourse, that all individuals have responsibility to engage and succeed as lifelong learners in which they flexibly accumulate human capital.

(Zipin et al. 2015, 233)

This description of the implications of justifying WP policy, which in England includes promoting HE in FE, with reference to human capital can be read as a warning against conflating WP with upward social mobility. If the aim of WP is associated with individuals’ responsibility for their own value in the workplace, then that aim has been achieved; more people in England have HE qualifications than ever before. By contrast, there is no evidence that social mobility based upon outcome has been achieved. In the UK this is hardly surprising when the 7 per cent of the population who attended private schools account for 71 per cent of senior judges and 45 per cent of the chairs of public bodies (Milburn 2014). That proportion is symbolic of inequality that no amount of employability training will affect. To avoid “hope-goading gloss” there is a need to be clear about the structural obstacles in the way of social mobility and hence social justice for those who invest the time and effort into achieving HE qualifications. What Bourdieu and Passeron wrote about the highly segmented French education system over forty years ago is relevant to the current

English context and elsewhere.

To grasp the social significance of the different social categories' share in the different faculties or disciplines, one has to take into account the *position* this or that faculty or discipline occupies at a given time within the system of faculties or disciplines.

(Bourdieu and Passeron 1990, 222; original emphasis)

The assumption that HE per se necessarily brings rewards in the form of improved social mobility needs to be refuted. In this regard Clegg has written:

In policy debates about higher education in the United Kingdom there has been a tendency to treat the definition of future desirable selves as obvious, tied to a rhetoric of employability and, in debates about student financial contribution to higher education, to the obvious advantages of social mobility.

(Clegg 2011, 102)

Those "obvious advantages" are illusory for many students because of the differentiated nature of HE in England, where data indicates that HE in FE qualifications reap lesser benefits than those from universities. Liu (2011, 391) echoes this in specific relation to degrees from City Colleges in America. She notes that in the name of meritocracy "higher education can be viewed as concurrently promoting social mobility and legitimizing stratification". She continues:

Meritocracy does not aim to create a classless society, but it legitimizes the given hierarchical structure and empowers people to be socially re-classified. Social class assignments are not absolute, and the resulting social order is seemingly more justifiable if one's higher status is earned.

(Liu 2011, 391)

In America as in England, therefore, the prospect of educational merit leading to social mobility may even make society's structural inequality appear legitimate.

The value of HE in FE

The implication for HE in FE tutors who strive to achieve social mobility for their students against powerful countervailing structural obstacles is that they are likely to fail, a stance that echoes Bernstein's (1970). Clegg identifies dangers associated

with this general failure, which question what social justice means if it is reduced to access to the right kind of HE.

Progressive educators practicing in less elite settings are trapped into a series of promises they cannot realise, while those in elite institutions are largely involved in a logic of reproduction not transformation. In describing and analysing these modes of reproduction it becomes all too easy to conceptualise the capitals minority students bring with them as lacking and thus to lay the blame for continued inequalities at the door of poor schools and families.

(Clegg 2011, 94)

For “poor schools”, we may also read poor FE colleges. Yet, Gorard’s article title, which echoes Bernstein, is perhaps more appropriate: “Education can compensate for society – a bit” (Gorard 2010). While HE in FE has not consistently led to upward social mobility at a macro level, HE in FE courses can help to enlighten lives and expose opportunities for many individual students. Assessing the systematic economic outcomes of HE in FE is important, but those are not the only criteria by which to judge the value of college-based HE, at least for individual students. What Gale graphically explains for the context of Australian HE also holds for England:

While university student recruitment departments focus on ‘bums on seats’, equity advocates draw attention to which bums, in what proportions and, more to the point, which seats, where. But if the counting of ‘bums’ is crude, so is the differentiation of seats. Just distinguishing between courses and universities and scrutinizing the distribution of groups is a limited view of equity.

(Gale 2012, 138)

Simply persuading more people from disadvantaged backgrounds onto HE in FE courses is, perhaps, an example of such a limited view of equity. HE in FE has other worth and HE in FE tutors may do better to focus on the use value of their courses rather than on economic returns or the alienating discourse of employability. In a similar vein Gorard (2010) found little evidence of compulsory schooling overcoming “initial disparity in the resources and attainment of school intakes”. His tentative optimism, the ‘bit’ of change that society might make, was based on educational outcomes that are “more widely envisaged, including learning to trust and willingness to help others, aspirations, and attitudes to continuing in education and training.” Recontextualising this for HE in FE tutors means focusing on the curriculum, pedagogy and articulation of knowledge (see also Clegg 2011). What Bathmaker has written about vocational courses applies also to HE in FE, many of which are vocational in any case:

The issue of knowledge is not just a technical question, but relates to questions of equity [equality] and justice. If vocational education qualifications are to enable people to gain valuable knowledge and skills, and are to open up opportunities rather than constrain and limit futures, then questions of knowledge in these qualifications, and how these questions are decided, are crucial.

(Bathmaker 2013, p. 88)

Wheelahan's (2010, p. 9) parallel discussion of access to knowledge is also instructive. "The privileged access of the powerful to theoretical abstract knowledge provides them with the ability to mobilize knowledge to think the unthinkable and the not-yet-thought." HE in FE may provide access to that type of powerful knowledge as situated within subjects or vocational areas. That may not change society, but it might change lives (and see Avis 2016).

Conclusion

HE in FE faces all the contradictions that surround education systems that are set within neo-liberal and capitalist contexts. In the preceding we have examined a range of issues that address inequality and class relations. Whilst we have pointed towards the messiness and complexity of HE in FE, in that this is not all of a piece, nevertheless in the same way as FE and VET are for other people's children so too with HE in FE. HE in FE tends to recruit students from the more disadvantaged sectors of the population. The warning of Zipin et al. (2013, 227-8) is pertinent here: "optimism is a cruel experience for many in the historic present, given lived conditions fraught with structural obstacles that thwart even the most reasonable strategies for pursuing futures hopefully." Taking an HE in FE course constitutes one such reasonable strategy prone to cruel optimism because HE in FE cannot systematically lessen social or economic disadvantages. FE colleges, like their international counterparts such as Community Colleges, can only reflect and not transform unequal societies (Tight 2012, 213), despite the rhetoric of human capital that has become associated with social mobility policy. Moreover, any policy that promotes relative social mobility and ignores the consequent relative downward movement in society of groups or individuals is, to say the least, shortsighted. For many individuals, however, HE in FE courses can **and do** transform lives by opening up fields of knowledge that may explain and enhance experience. That is where college-based practitioners might direct their energy and so produce courses and curricula that value situated knowledge, the "not yet thought" (Bernstein 2000; Wheelahan 2010) and which may even challenge restrictive assumptions about social mobility. This would constitute an aspect of the struggle for social justice whereby students and teachers seek to collectively develop 'really useful knowledge'. Placing socially situated alongside really useful knowledge would serve to open up a broader vista and facilitate the formation of counter hegemonic movements. In the early sections of the paper we considered the HE in FE literature that pointed towards the manner in which class relations were played out in the sector. The point is, there are various sites of struggle that criss-cross the sector ranging from those that seeks to validate the para-professionalism of child care workers, the professional projects of those who deliver HE in FE as well as the

relationship of VET to the formation of class relations. As Bernstein and Apple remind us educational interventions can only take us so far. In some respects current capitalist developments rooted in neo-liberalism intensify these processes and the surrounding antagonism. These struggles need to be lodged in a wider politics that is committed to societal transformation. Without such a politics we are doomed, at best, to mitigate inequalities present in society. This can be seen in the systemic failure of widening participation to close the inequality gap between those who have attended HE in FE courses as against those studying at elite universities. Consequently, there is a need to develop a politics that extends beyond education to wider society and that aligns itself to social movements committed to social justice and transformation.

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Tables

	<i>POLAR3 quintiles</i>				
<i>Type of institution</i>	1	2	3	4	5
Taught at an HEI	10.0%	14.7%	19.1%	23.8%	32.4%
Taught at an FE college	19.3%	20.8%	22.0%	20.3%	17.5%
Overall	10.7%	15.2%	19.3%	23.5%	31.4%

Table 1: Distribution of young 2011 HE entrants by POLAR3 quintile, grouped by type of institution
(adapted from HEFCE, 2014c, p. 56)

	FSM	Non-FSM	Gap (%)	All
2005/06	13%	33%	19	30%
2006/07	14%	33%	19	31%
2007/08	15%	33%	18	31%
2008/09	17%	35%	18	33%
2009/10	18%	36%	18	34%
2010/11	20%	38%	18	35%

Table 2: Estimated percentage of maintained school pupils aged 15 by Free School Meal (FSM) status, who entered UK HE (HEIs and FE colleges) by age 19 in academic years 2005/06 to 2010/11 (DBIS, 2013, p. 4)

		% disclosed salary	Lower quartile	Upper quartile	Median salary	Mean salary
First degree						
	English FEC	88%	£12,000	£20,000	£15,000	£16,500
	English HEI	71%	£15,000	£23,000	£19,000	£20,000
Foundation degree						
	English FEC	85%	£12,000	£19,000	£15,000	£16,500
	English HEI	63%	£16,000	£27,000	£20,000	£21,500
Other undergraduates						
	English FEC	81%	£13,000	£25,000	£18,000	£20,000
	English HEI	71%	£21,000	£23,000	£21,500	£22,000
All undergraduates						
	English FEC	86%	£12,000	£20,000	£15,000	£17,500
	English HEI	70%	£15,000	£24,000	£20,000	£20,000

Table 3: UK domiciled full-time undergraduate leavers from English FECs and HEIs entering full-time paid employment in the UK, by level of qualification obtained and salary, 2010-11 (HEFCE, 2013, annex c11)